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Conversation Starters, Not Enders

The husband-wife duo started out as travel vloggers covering Indian and foreign destinations, until the Covid-19 pandemic warranted a change in content strategy. Soon, Abhiraj, who has studied filmmaking, and Niyati, a chartered accountant-turned-freelance writer, began to cover history and culture, tales of inspiring Indians and began to raise awareness about issues .

It's a decision that's paid dividends. In March, they were awarded the New India Champion award at the National Creators Award by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. At the event, Abhi said their aim was to combat the barrage of negative commentary about "Bharat" by highlighting positive stories best reflected in their show, *Hundred Reasons to Love India*. "We don't want to impose our opinion on our audience, that is why whenever we make content on election, at the end we say this should be a conversation-starter, not ender," they say.



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politician on their channel—Piyush Goyal giving a tour of Bharat Mandapam—and one they insist wasn't a paid promotion, having borne the cost of travel and stay themselves. More opportunities to engage with politicians have come their way, but the couple says they ensure they "have complete control over content. We don't share questions and edits before the interview". Their endeavour, say Abhiraj and Niyati, is to make the youth curious and engage with what's happening around them. "A lot of the time they feel powerless. They feel they don't have agency to change or fix things," they say. Rather than focus on problems, Abhi and Niyu aim to offer solutions.

WHILE DHRUV RATHEE IS SEEN AS A CHAMPION OF THE LEFT LIBERALS, THE RIGHT ROOTS FOR THE LIKES OF ABHI & NIYU, AKTK AND THE JAIPUR DIALOGUES

WOOING THE INFLUENCERS

Image guru and political communications strategist Dilip Cherian has worked with political parties in six Lok Sabha elections so far and seen how social media has been used to influence the discourse. The campaign for the 2024 polls, he notes, has enabled YouTubers "to chop and chip" material to upload on Instagram and YouTube. He also points to the growing influence of regional vloggers. "You find a much larger number of local voices being followed and listened to. This was especially prevalent in Andhra Pradesh and Odisha which had simultaneous assembly elections," he says. "The way to use them was to allow a certain flexing of their neutrality muscle to attract views."

Political parties see advantages in hobnobbing with the influencers. In an event held in May in Delhi, the Congress, while discussing its manifesto, invited Dr Medusa to interact with the young audience. A linguist by profession, she says it was the first time the party had approached her and that it wasn't a paid gig. "At my core, I am an anti-establishment person. Whoever is in power, I will question them," she says. Other parties have approached her to endorse certain narratives, but she's determined to not curry favour or take money. "If I start doing that, then tomorrow, if they are in power, there will be a problem if I question them," she adds. "My credibility is my most important tool. My payment is if someone